



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
HARVARD BUSINESS SCHOOL

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

The Harvard Business School has a brand like no other business school in the world. And it is this magnetic appeal that persuades a record-breaking 10,351 hopefuls to compete for one of the 940 places in its MBA program. The HBS Admissions team is made up of only five key individuals, so it is no surprise that many applicants very quickly fall by the wayside, given their lack of professional credentials and academic excellence. Indeed, for some the process is akin to burning a dozen or so \$20 bills.

Such limited staff resources may in part explain the school's move towards a shorter, more streamlined application in recent years. HBS now only requires two recommendations, and in the past three years has moved from four essays down to just one essay. Your resume and recommendations have never carried so much weight.

HBS has more CEOs of Fortune 500 companies than any other MBA program, a couple of former Presidents (U.S. and Mexico), and an unrivalled global network of influence. This conservative symbol of success, with its old red brick campus and the highest admissions yield, nevertheless faces a battle to win the hearts of minds of the tech industry. For many applicants, the closest they will get to a Harvard MBA is a T-shirt, but for a select few it will be the experience of a lifetime.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

With a world-renowned faculty, HBS can claim academic excellence in many fields. Perhaps best known for General Management and a dedication to the case method, the school touts Leadership, Entrepreneurship, Strategy and CSR among the top areas of study.

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 9,228
Admissions Selectivity: 12 %
Total Tuition: \$146,880

MBA Class Size: 938
Yield: 85%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 29%; Consulting 21%; Technology 20%; Healthcare 6%; Starting a Business 7%

Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Goldman Sachs, BCG, Bain, Morgan Stanley & Co
Avg. Base Salary: \$146,880 Employment in 3 months: 94%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	2	-	8	1	1	-	3	3
Financial Times	2	1	1	1	2	4	3	2
Forbes	-	1	-	3	-	2	-	4
The Economist	4	6	6	4	4	4	3	2
US News	1	1	1	2	1	1	1	3

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 27 yrs
Int'l Students: 37%

Avg. GMAT: 730
Female Students: 43%

Avg. GPA: 3.70

Deadlines for 2020-2021: R1 - Sept 4, '20 R2 - Jan 6, '20
In 2018, HBS eliminated round 3.

Sources: Harvard, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2020-2021:

As we review your application, what more would you like us to know as we consider your candidacy for the Harvard Business School MBA program?

There is no word limit for this question. We think you know what guidance we're going to give here. Don't overthink, over-craft and overwrite. Just answer the question in clear language that those of us who don't know your world can understand.

What HBS Really Wants from Your MBA Essay

By Karla Cohen

Karla spent three years as Associate Director of Doctoral Programs at Harvard Business School (HBS), overseeing admissions, marketing, and recruitment as well as providing broader administrative support for the Doctoral Programs Office. She also served on the MBA interview board for the HBS MBA program and partnered with the MBA team to identify and recruit high potential students for admission.

I'll get straight to the point: Your essay is the make or break factor for HBS. It's the essay that sets your overall application apart and earns you the interview amid so many applications with impressive credentials. You can't expect to compete on credentials alone at any top tier business school, let alone Harvard, because HBS has seen it all.

Don't get me wrong – your credentials are incredibly important, but they only get you to the threshold. Short answers are also a critical element often overlooked for levity too. But once you've reached a certain level of exceptionalism in terms of being brilliant, dedicated and driven, it's about your story. A great essay will entice the reader to say wow, I cannot wait to meet this person and learn more. And if that feels intimidating, remember this: No one else has lived your story but you, so you're the one best poised to tell it. Think of it like drafting a "movie trailer" for your life – your essay should be engaging, interesting, dramatic and fast paced.

Here are my top five tips for writing a powerful HBS essay:

1. Do NOT display a highlights reel of professional achievements.

The biggest temptation – and the biggest snooze – is a "resume to prose" essay, which will put your wearied admissions reader to sleep. And frankly, staying awake was the biggest challenge I faced when reading applications, from my time at INSEAD to HBS and even admissions work at Stanford. Too many applicants wrote essays that were boring, lifeless, and dull. What really made my eyes glaze over were narratives from candidates who sailed through life, having never failed or struggled, who always excelled at everything and then segued to the details of some deal or consulting project. This can't be overstated: Your essay must not read simply as a story of successes and accomplishments. It's a common pitfall, and it robs your story the potential for making an emotional connection. Above all, write an essay you yourself would want to read.

So, when HBS asks you, "what else do you want us to know?" the focus is on the "what ELSE." You have already detailed your job experiences in the short answer section of the application along with your resume. Do not restate these same facts again, and again. Remember, they know what consultants and bankers do in the office, so unless you are introducing something new or connecting your work to a broader theme, avoid trying to "show off" by writing at length about work achievements.



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2. Be open, imperfect, and REAL.

I find it disheartening that my strongest piece of advice, which is to tell the truth and be yourself, is also so difficult at times. Most people are afraid to be real, and they spend hours polishing and perfecting an “image” or “brand” that is an illusion. When you take the risk to be yourself, to be vulnerable, it inspires a human connection. It gives you credibility. What’s more interesting to read – the story of someone who sailed through life and had everything work out perfectly, every single time? Or the story of someone who struggled, faced extraordinary challenges, and demonstrated the tenacity and resilience to not only survive but to thrive?

That’s why the more personal and open you can be in terms of why you do what you do, the more memorable and appealing you’ll be. Because so few people are. Few people are rigorously honest, and fewer are vulnerable in the process of storytelling. Some of the best essays I have ever read open with the story of a failure and how that shaped them. From my perspective, if you are never making mistakes, you aren’t working hard enough. Besides, there is something so powerful about the truth when you read it – it hits you and tunes up your curiosity. And that’s what you want to inspire – enough enthusiasm and curiosity for the admissions committee to want to meet you and learn more. Always remember – this is a search for authenticity.

3. Show vs. tell.

In the process of storytelling, the details are everything. Avoid the temptation to qualify your experience or tell the readers what they are supposed to think. Show them instead. For example, what is more powerful – someone saying, “I had a horrible flight,” or, “We pulled onto the runway, and I could see from my window the dark clouds above; the captain announced once cleared for takeoff, we were in for a bumpy ride. I could feel my pulse quickening.” While you want to avoid detailing a terrible flight experience for the HBS adcom, this concept is critical for effective storytelling. Show them what you have been through and the challenges you have faced through vivid recollection. A consultant can help you sift through your experience to help you identify what to focus on. Generally, experiences that shaped your values and attitude toward life are a great place to start. You might talk about a challenge, for example, or a time you fell and picked yourself back up. Underscore how it shaped you as a human being and what you learned from the experience and remember to SHOW them the impact vs. simply telling them.

4. Connect the dots.

Your essay should have what I refer to as the “thread of continuity” that will serve as a unifying theme. Perhaps, you can introduce an experience that was momentous or marked an important milestone in your opening paragraph. As you weave together stories that show the committee who you are and the twists and turns your life has taken, you will want to revisit this theme at different points in your story as a way to unify the narrative. The conclusion should serve to tie it all together. This may sound formulaic, but when in doubt, rest assured this is a tried and true model that allows you to connect the dots for your reader. Any great story or even speech – from Martin Luther King’s I Have A Dream to the latest Hollywood blockbuster – has a cohesive flow and pace that keep the audience’s attention. There is always an intangible driving force that builds, which is an essential ingredient to a winning essay.

5. Respect the reader’s time.

While there’s no given word count, try to keep your essay within 2,000 words, or three-to-four pages. This may surprise you if you’ve been advised stay within 800 – 1,000 words, but the truth is content is everything and some stories need more space. And if it’s too short, admissions may assume you are being inauthentic or following misguided advice. And while



there's no hard-and-fast rule, I don't recommend going over 2,000 words. Most of my clients land somewhere between 800 to 1,500 – being pithy and succinct also shows discipline and humility. That said, one of the most powerful essays I have ever worked on with a client was one word under 2,000, and the feedback he received in the interview was that his essay was one of the best the committee had ever read, and his interviewer thanked him for his openness and honesty.

HBS is looking for people who are extraordinary and ambitious, with an impressive track record, a habit of leadership, and a penchant for consistently hitting their goals. More than that, they're seeking mission-driven individuals who are motivated by a deeper purpose and poised to make the institution proud. If you can fuse that with a captivating story of who you are as an individual, you tip the odds in your favor.

POST-INTERVIEW REFLECTION

As part of the application process, HBS requires interviewees to complete a Post-Interview Reflection. This is not intended to be another formal essay. Think of it instead as an email you might write to a colleague or supervisor after a meeting.

HBS will be much more generous in its reaction to typos and grammatical errors than they'll be with pre-packaged responses. Reflections that give any indication that they were produced BEFORE you had the interview will raise a flag for the Admissions Committee.

Your Post-Interview Reflection is due within 24 hours of the conclusion of your interview. There is no word limit for the Post-Interview Reflection.

For tips on how to tackle, view Karla's article in Poets&Quants on [Writing Your Post-Interview Reflection](#).



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By Malvina Miller Complainville

Malvina worked as the Assistant Director of Careers Services at Harvard Business School and led the Programs and Communication team, developing career development programs for HBS students. In this capacity, Malvina provided hundreds of hours of one-on-one career coaching to HBS students. In addition to this experience, Malvina was head of Talent for the Luxury Products Division at L'Oreal USA and was responsible for full-time and intern MBA selection, as well as designing and heading the Marketing Management Development Program for Luxury.

Tip #1 - Stand out from your peer group

Given the thousands upon thousands of candidates that HBS gets to choose from, successful candidates are those who manage to show how they stand out from the crowd. The HBS admissions team puts a great deal of effort into crafting a diverse and dynamic classroom, with individuals who will bring perspective and experience that is different from their fellow classmates. Candidates who have strong experience but whose profile seems undifferentiated from the hundreds or thousands of other candidates from the same sector are not going to make the cut. So give some deep thought to what is unique about your background and about your potential contribution to the program. If you can convince the admissions team that you have a truly unique profile, you will have a much better chance of succeeding. If you have a common profile and have some months or years before you plan to apply, think about how you could gain some differentiating experience that you will be able to highlight on your application.

Tip #2 - Showcase your leadership

Leadership is at the core of the Harvard experience. HBS is known as the school for general management training, specifically developing leaders who will "contribute to the well being of society." The admissions office gives greater weight to leadership experience, and less weight to intellectual horsepower than some other top schools. So when applying to HBS, make sure your leadership experience comes across prominently, not just as a one-off, but as a pattern of leadership that can be demonstrated at different stages of your development. This leadership experience can come from your professional work experience, academics, hobbies, extracurricular activities and community work. So before you sit down to work on your Harvard application you need to take the time to identify instances from all aspects of your life that point to your ability or instinct to lead. You should also touch on your future leadership role in your essays and interview. What positive impact will you have on your chosen industry?

Tip #3 - Articulate a clear, ambitious and realistic career vision

Reflect on how your career vision aligns with HBS's values. Like other business schools, HBS discusses in detail their values on their website and in social media so make sure you are clear on what these are. Your career vision should be detailed, with short-term goals and long-term goals. It should be ambitious and achievable. And if it seems to you that west coast rival Stanford GSB has cornered the market in careers that change lives and change organizations, think again. Harvard is equally interested in finding out what impact you intend to have on an institution, an industry and the world.

You should also think of two different paths that could lead you to your long-term career goals; this gives you more flexibility if one of your short-term goals prove challenging to achieve.



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Tip #4 - Spend time fine-tuning your resume

The resume is often the first element that the file reader will review, so it needs to pack a punch. And with Harvard now down to only one essay your resume has never been more important. Make sure that the strength of your credentials comes across very strongly. Highlight your achievements and the impact you had in your roles. Quantify your achievements and impact with specific numbers wherever possible. HBS is looking for candidates on a rapid career trajectory, so make sure your evolution (promotions, increasing scope of responsibility, etc.) is clearly demonstrated.

Remember that people who are not from your industry may be confused by jargon or acronyms so avoid these. You may want to write a short description under each company if the admissions team might not be familiar with it; this is especially important for work experience abroad. In general, use action verbs and remove passive sentences or phrases. HBS has a strong preference for a one-page resume. You may want to consider adopting the HBS resume format. This will make it easier for Admissions to read your resume, as they will be familiar with the style and layout, and if you are accepted, you will have one less thing to do when it is time for resume writing time.

Tip #5 - Demonstrate strong communication skills

Class participation makes up 50% of the student grade. You are expected to speak up confidently and participate actively in class. The case method requires that you listen carefully to the discussion unfolding in the classroom and be prepared to jump in and share an insightful point in a clear and concise manner. In your application, you should think of how you can showcase your strong communication skills – for instance, discuss your success presenting in public and engaging in debates.

Tip #6 - Coach your recommenders

Recommendation letters are extremely important to HBS, and admissions strongly prefers direct supervisors. They place a great deal of weight on who has written the letter – more so than many other schools. It is important to have a really detailed letter that strongly champions your case for admission, with specific examples that are clearly personal to you – so spend some time with your recommenders discussing the strengths they could highlight and the examples they could use. HBS also places great importance on how the recommender compares the candidate to his or her peer group, even to other candidates that the recommender has written for in the past. This is of particular importance for those applicants coming from a traditional feeder sector to business school, such as consulting or financial services. With competition from so many others with comparable experience, Harvard is looking for the best of the best, so benchmarking your performance is very useful to them.

Tip #7 - Take advantage of the open essay

The HBS essay is not mandatory; however, consider it an important opportunity to tell your story and show how you are different from the other applicants. HBS will have your resume, application and recommendation letters so do not repeat information that the school can find elsewhere, otherwise your essay will be quickly passed over. Do not just expound further on professional accomplishments that are (or should be) in your resume. Think about what else in your profile, history and experiences is of relevance to HBS and is not apparent elsewhere in your application. The HBS essay has no word limit, however remember the school appreciates conciseness. Essay writing should be to the point, stay away from flowery language, and instead use business-writing style. When writing this essay remember that HBS is looking for individuals who are innovative thinkers. They do not want cookie-cutter candidates so do not try to portray what you think HBS is looking for. Show that you have your own ideas.



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Tip #8 - Prepare for your interview

The HBS interview is professional and formal; in the course of 30 minutes, the interviewer from the HBS admissions office will probe areas of your application with pointed questions and follow up questions. You should know your resume inside and out. Be ready to discuss at length the reasons for your career moves and what you achieved in each position. Your answers will naturally raise follow up questions, so only raise topics you are comfortable discussing further.

The interviewer will be looking to evaluate your interpersonal skills, your cultural fit with HBS, your confidence (but not overconfidence), and what you will contribute to the program. Try to show the individual that you are beyond what they know about you already. Show your individuality.

Tip #9 - Authenticity in the post interview reflection

In addition to the application and the interview, HBS has a unique "post interview reflection". Interviewed applicants are required to write a letter within 24 hours of their interview. HBS does not provide a word count for this but again, being concise is important. The point of the 24-hour deadline is that the school wants you to be spontaneous and authentic: the piece you submit should not sound like it was written before the interview. Your letter should be based on the conversation you had and is your opportunity to communicate something that you didn't have the chance to say, or even to correct something that you think didn't come across quite right.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, LBS, Kellogg, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson, Yale SOM, NYU Stern & Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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